

Introduction

Toni Herbine-Blank developed the couple therapy Intimacy from the Inside Out (IFIO) as a branch of Internal Family Systems (IFS) therapy, a treatment used for individuals, couples, families, communities, and organizations. Intimate relationships inevitably pose painful dilemmas and require partners to navigate differences. If they cannot differentiate and stay connected in the process, they end up experiencing, as Dan Siegel wrote, emotional chaos or rigidity (2007). IFIO is designed to help partners differentiate and stay connected by accessing their strengths (Herbine-Blank, Kerpelman, & Sweezy, 2016). When we speak and listen skillfully, we deepen and transform our relationships. In IFIO, we aim for partners to disagree respectfully, communicate courageously, apologize from the heart, forgive freely, and stay connected. Loving connection leads to ongoing well-being.

This book walks readers through the flow of IFIO descriptively and experientially, weaving interpersonal communication techniques with deep intrapsychic exploration. It guides therapists and couples to intervene effectively in patterns of conflict, move from protective power struggles to vulnerable conversations without attack or silence, and use an essential IFS technique called *unblending* to understand themselves and others.

In the first section, we introduce the conceptual underpinnings of IFIO, including the idea that we all have motivated, active subpersonalities (or *parts*), who influence our views and behavior, and two easily accessible, crucial skills: (1) differentiating (or *unblending*) from parts in order to be in relationship with them and (2) attending internally (or doing a *U-turn*) in order to help parts in moments of reactivity.

In the second section, we provide step-by-step techniques, case examples, and exercises for use with clients in each phase of IFIO treatment. Phase one: We connect with the couple, assesses their relational dynamics, introduce them to IFIO, and start befriending their protective parts. Phase two: We track patterns of conflict and help partners unblend so they can speak for parts and listen from the heart. We aim for the couple to appreciate the inevitability (and acceptability) of differences so they can differentiate from each other comfortably, stay connected, and practice talking in ways that haven't

t been possible for a long time, if ever. Phase three: We help them explore the meaning of apology and forgiveness, give them the opportunity to engage in both, and set the stage for them to support each other in healing emotional wounds that predate their relationship.

The third section explains how patterns of autonomic reactivity underlie the compulsive behaviors at the core of a couple's relational dynamics and illustrates how to discuss these phenomena with couples.

Finally, the book's fourth section describes some common challenges for couple therapists, while the fifth section provides additional experiential exercises so partners can rescript and repair conflictual interactions.

Because the IFIO approach is best grasped experientially, we recommend that therapists try these exercises personally before using them with clients. Try them with a partner, friend, or colleague. Alternatively, try them in your mind's eye with your own polarized parts, with someone you know, or with a couple you find manageable.